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Evaluation Criteria for Performance Appraisal of faculty Members

Elena Arnăutu^a, Ioana Panc^{*a}

^aUniversity Titu Maiorescu, Calea Vacaresti 187, Bucharest, Romania

Abstract

“Evaluation criteria for performance appraisal of faculty members” is an interdisciplinary study situated in between the concern for the quality of the education process and efficient human resources management. These two needs (quality in education and efficiency in the management of human resources) can be addressed through the introduction of a system of performance appraisal for faculty members. The purpose of the present study is to create a valid and objective tool of evaluating and appraising faculty members.

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1. Introduction

Performance appraisal has become a term used for a variety of activities through which organizations seek to assess employees and develop their competence, improve performance, and allocate rewards (Fletcher, 2001). The literature is abundant in studies regarding performance appraisal, performance review, performance evaluation, performance assessment, performance measurement, employee evaluation, personnel review, staff assessment, service rating, etc. (Murphy & Cleveland, 1995). Most of them, however, refer to the for profit organizations. The high-paced evolution of science and technology, the implementation of new technologies and the globalization of competitive market enhance the need for evaluation of the personnel inside organizations (Bogathy, 2007).

Grote (2002) identified the following purposes of performance appraisal: Providing feedback to employees about their performance, facilitating decisions concerning pay increases, promotions, layoffs; encouraging performance improvement; setting and measuring goals; determining individual and organizational training and development

* Corresponding author.

E-mail address: ioana.panc@prof.utm.ro

needs; confirming that good hiring decisions are being made; provide legal support for personnel decisions; improving overall organizational performance. Within the educational system, another need joins the aforementioned ones: the ethical need to bring the education to a higher level of performance.

Generally speaking, performance appraisal serves two basic purposes: the first is evaluative (or administrative) as the term “appraisal” implies, and the second is developmental (Rynes, Gerhart, & Parks, 2005)

The budgets for institutions of higher education have high labor content and their budgets are primarily devoted to personnel expenses (Johnsrud, 2002). Their success significantly relies upon superior faculty, administrators, and staff. Nevertheless, colleges and universities are not known for their consideration of human resource issues as they pertain to the quality of work life on campus for their employees.

The purpose of the present study is to create a valid and objective tool of evaluating and appraising faculty members. The tool offers to accurately and exhaustively evaluate the performance appraisal of faculty members, so that the attained results are relevant to both the subject of the evaluation, highlighting the areas that need improving and the students, who are the final recipients of the education process.

As a secondary objective, the present study aims to find and evaluate differences between the perception of the students and the perception of the professors in understanding the performance of faculty members. For this present study, the method of qualitative analysis was used.

2. Performance rating method

To identify the criteria for performance appraisal of faculty members, the behaviorally anchored rating scales (BARS) will be used. This instrument allows an objective evaluation, it can be easily handled by unexperienced evaluators (such as students) and it can effortlessly differentiate between a good faculty member and a less than satisfactory one (Wiersma, U.J., Berg, P.T van den, Latham, G.P., 1992).

The evaluation tool was elaborated according to the steps recommended in the literature (Pitariu, 2000):

Step I: A group of subject matter experts – faculty and students - was requested to write a set of factors (dimensions) that allows assessment of a faculty as specialist. The generated dimensions were put together, the redundant ones were eliminated and the list was debated once more with the request to create explanatory definitions for each of the dimensions. The procedure was repeated with two groups of subject matter experts in order to increase objectivity.

Step II: The list of dimensions, along with their definitions was attributed to a group of 30 specialists (faculty members and students) with the indication to provide one or two examples that described a behavior of high, medium and inferior professional performance for each dimensions. After the examples were collected, they were synthesized in a list; the redundant and monotonous examples were removed.

Step III: A list of the dimensions and their definitions and another list of examples of behaviors were given to a new group of experts (30 individuals). The items on the list were arranged randomly. The task of this group was to assign each behavioral example to the category or dimension it belongs to. Only the items (examples) with a re-allocation success rate of 67% were kept.

Step IV: The kept items were grouped according to dimensions and a leaflet was put together. The leaflet contained a page of instructions followed by as many pages as dimensions identified. Each dimension and its definition are located in the upper side of the page, followed by the items, written down in a random order. A group of approximately 20 experts and evaluators (professors and students) was asked to individually grade each item, on a scale from one to nine. It is a balancing action and one of rating behavioral anchors. Out of the final list of items, the median and the standard deviation were calculated. The items chosen for the final scale possess the following qualities: they have medial values that cover almost entirely the length of the scale and they have a small standard deviation.

3. Participants

The group of subject matter experts consisted of faculty members and students. The motivation behind selecting students to be a part of the experts is that they are the recipients of the educational process and thus, they are important in evaluating the performance of faculty members.

For the first stage of the study, there were 15 experts (7 faculty and 6 professors). They identified and categorized the dimensions. For the second stage of the study, 30 specialists (15 faculty and 15 students) identified the behaviors (high, median and inferior) for each of the dimensions. For the third stage, a new group of experts was in charge of re-translating the behavioral examples back into their respective performance dimensions. The last group of experts, 10 faculty and 10 students, was in charge of balancing and locating behavioral anchors on the scale.

In total, there were 60 experts (30 faculty and 30 students). The age of the participants was between 20 and 60 years. Out of the entire group, 62% were women and 39% men.

4. Analysis and Interpretation of the Results

Ten dimensions that allow faculty members to be assessed were identified. For each dimension, participants gave definitions comprised in Table 1.

Table 1. Defined assessment dimensions for faculty performance appraisal

	Dimension name	Dimension definition
Factor A	Comprehensive knowledge in the teaching field	Updated and correct knowledge in their teaching field. The permanent desire to learn more about their own area of expertise (subject matter) and their professional field. The capacity to capitalize on their own experience.
Factor B	Deontology and availability for teacher-student communication	Moral behaviour, honesty, objectivity, modesty, non-discriminatory attitude, impartiality, not being involved in scandals with the students. Availability to help students when they require.
Factor C	Presentation skills	Ease of speaking, ability to juggle with expressions and words and adapt them to the needs of the auditorium. The capacity to maintain the interest of the students, the capacity to keep the attention of the auditorium.
Factor D	Passion for teaching	Enthusiasm and vitality. A genuine love for teaching. The tendency to gather all of their energy and put it in the process of teaching and research.
Factor E	Class preparation and management	The capacity of the professor to convey information in an attractive manner. The use of a plethora of methods meant to increase the degree of efficiency of the class.
Factor F	Student examination	The quality of ongoing and final evaluation of students: objectivity, correctness, respecting evaluation criteria and attaining education objectives.
Factor G	Quality of teaching materials	The quality of teaching materials for students. Quality is understood here as curricular innovation, coherence, textual accuracy, logic of subject selection, practical implication, exercises, grading important aspects.
Factor H	Research and scientific productivity	Preoccupation for research and scientific productivity. Discovery of new information and integration of knowledge, as well as involvement in scientific research. For evaluation, both quantitative and qualitative criteria will be taken into consideration.
Factor I	Administrative skills	Active implication in human resource management and logistics inside the department/faculty/university to attain institution's objectives.
Factor J	Reputation	Good national or international reputation. Good grasp of the knowledge and abilities of their own field. Connections to the job market and other professional services.

Table 2 presents the behavioral anchors identified for high performance on each of the dimensions.

Table 2. Behavioral Anchors

Dimension	Behavioural Anchors for high performance
Comprehensive knowledge of the teaching field	They have updated information in their teaching field
	They are receptive to new trends and share them with their students
	They frequently offer relevant examples from their professional expertise
	They revise and update the class materials every year

Deontology and availability for teacher-student communication	They use concepts from their professional area with ease
	They are interested in the professional evolution of their students
	They promote professional ethics in the students' future careers
	They keep to their moral principles no matter the circumstances
	They show a non-discriminatory and impartial behaviour in their relationship with their students
	They offer consultations to students
	They offer online support to students
Presentation skills	They facilitate the students' independent learning process
	They manage to keep the attention of the students for the entire class
	During class there is a dialogue meant to clarify the information that is presented
	They get students involved in the explanation and demonstration of the theory
	They use audio-visual support (power point presentations)
Passion for teaching	They use technology in their presentations
	They are charismatic
	They convey enthusiasm for their field, both verbally and nonverbally
	Aside from theory and practice, they should inspire the students to get involved
Class preparation and management	They are available to share the information they know, that goes beyond the class requirements
	They organize their class according to the feedback they receive
	They offer concrete examples to hard-to-understand concepts
	They adapt the teaching methods to their student's needs
	They have clear class objectives and they follow a systematic plan to attain them
	They make connections between previous themes. They make sure previous information is understood, before introducing new information
	They keep their class during the proposed time frame
Student Examination	They follow the conventional curriculum
	They offer feedback to the student to help them develop
	Their evaluation of students is based on the students' capacity to apply the theory, not just repeat it
	They evaluate the capacity of the student for analysis and synthesis
	Their examination of the students tests both high and low level of cognitive abilities
Quality of teaching materials	The examination involves relevant aspects of the class
	The evaluation is performed in a correct and consistent manner
	They are preoccupied with elaborating additional teaching materials (case studies)
	They find a balance between the difficulty level of the class and the information sent to students
Research and scientific productivity	They are clear in expressing tasks and subjects which are found in the class contents
	There is proof of curricular innovation
	The themes that are researched are highly complex and are perceived as being a novelty in the field
	They publish in C, B, DBI or ISI journals
Administrative skills	They bring new research projects to the institutions they belong to. They win research projects via national competition (for directors)
	They are affiliated at national or international research centres (over the past 5 years)
	The articles they published are theoretically and methodologically rigorous
Administrative skills	They bring their contribution to the development of the department/faculty/university

Reputation	They initiate study programs, postgraduate courses, training and development courses
	They know the structures, interactions and organizational objectives. They integrate them and understand them
	They are preoccupied with the promotion of the institution's image
	They have been a moderator or a keynote speaker at international scientific conferences over the past 5 years
	They are a member of the editorial committee of ISI and BDI journals
	They have been a member of an international scientific committee over the past 5 years
	They have been an associate professor or a visiting professor at an abroad university for at least one month
	They have participated in professional associations
	They have participated in media events in their field
	They have performed services in the national evaluation committees

Differences between the professors' perception and that of the students were noted when it came to the description of the role of a faculty member and their performance appraisal. The differences are described below:

From the students' perspective, the role of the university professor is to guide and perform the teaching process. Aside from this, the students consider that a very important dimension in the performance appraisal of faculty members is availability for students.

From the faculty's perspective, their role should be split between teaching, researching and administration inside the university.

Due to these differences, factors H, I, J from the current tool will be used for a 360-type feedback evaluation, only in the cases of self-evaluation, peer evaluation and supervisor evaluation. This means that the students do not have the aptitudes and information necessary to evaluate the performance of the faculty as a researcher and active member of the faculty.

Some differences were found concerning the functions and attributions of the teaching process:

From the students' perspective, the most powerful and influential factor in the performance appraisal of faculty members is the relationship between professors and students. This was observed in the stage I of elaborating the BARS.

From the faculty's perspective, the teaching process should be focused more on the quality of the process and less on the relationship between professors and students. In the behavioral descriptions, the professors used quality criteria for the materials used for teaching (presentation, manuals, studies, etc.) and the information presented to the student (updated information).

When it comes to the conveying of information, there have been observed the following differences:

The student considers that it is necessary to understand what they are being taught and consider the correlation between theory and application (practical examples) to be of extreme importance.

The professor considers that the most important factor is to transmit updated information to their students.

In the evaluation process, the following differences have been observed:

From the students' perspective, the main function of the evaluation process is that of offering specific and personalized feedback to the student. Also, the students consider that it is of paramount importance for the professor to take the necessary measures when fraud is detected during exams. As for the content of the evaluation, the students believe that a good professor should offer evaluations based more on practical measures and less on theory.

From the faculty's point of view the evaluation process should focus on accuracy of the evaluation (the correlation between evaluation and teaching objectives, teaching plans covered, correctly managed time, etc.)

The deontological behavior is also perceived differently:

The students consider that a good teacher should be interested in the professional evolution of their students and should not be biased, but impartial in every situation.

The professors consider that a good teacher should promote professional ethics in their students' future professions.

5. Study conclusions, implications and limitations

The present tool – the behaviorally anchored rating scales or BARS – satisfies a need in the education system; the need for having objective and professional methods of performance evaluation of faculty.

Performance evaluation is a continuous and systematic process that helps the organization assesses its candidates through comparison to the accepted standards. For the evaluation to take place correctly there is a need for precise measuring techniques. The evaluation criteria need to be correctly formulated with the accepted standards, clearly defined and easy to observe. Behaviourally anchored rating scales respect the constraints of an efficient evaluation tool.

The 360-degrees feedback evaluation ensures objectivity in evaluation, by offering the assessee the possibility of adjusting their image of their own performance through others' perspective.

The utility of performance appraisal of personnel with a valid tool is obvious for both the employee – who identifies their strong points and the areas that require improving, and the managers (deans, rectors) who uncover the efficiency of their employees. The tool is also vital in planning professional trainings, improving future productivity, adjusting wage, establishing personnel distribution, highlighting the needs for training and development, etc.

The novelty of this present study is the introduction of the students in the group of experts that determined the evaluation criteria of the performance appraisal of faculty members. With this in mind, it is vital to note the difference between the perspective of the students and that of the faculty members in what makes a good professor.

The difference that had the most impact is the one that defines the role of a faculty. From the students' perspective, the role of the faculty is that of a teacher, the one who offers information, whereas from the faculty's perspective and some of the external performance standards imposed by legislation, the role is divided between teacher, researcher and service administrator (Miclea & Opre, 2001).

With this in mind, factors H (research and scientific productivity), I (administrative capacity), J (reputation) will not be presented in the evaluation made by students, given the fact that the students do not have the abilities and information necessary to evaluate the role that the professor has as a researcher or as an active member of the faculty.

Another notable difference has to do with the focus of activity; from the students' perspective a good professor should pay attention to the relationship between professors and students and offer personalized feedback, while professors believe that the attention should be focused on the quality of the education process (such as information update).

Therefore, the present study is proposing an evaluation instrument meant to optimize the methods for performance appraisal for faculty members. The study also helps increase the objectivity and efficiency in human resources management inside higher education institutions and the service offered to students.

6. Recommendations for future research and limitations of study

If we take into consideration the hypothesis that no study can be exhaustive, it is understandable and worth mentioning that this present study has its own limitations.

The first limitation of the study takes into consideration the students that took part. The group of experts (the students and the faculty members) was not represented at a national level for the entirety of the universities' profiles. The group of experts was built organically and it was based on the intentions of the group members to participate in the study. Therefore, there is a need for reexamination on a larger sample. Also, the selection of group members on a more rigorous criterion would also help (for example: relevant experience needed to define evaluation criteria of faculty members).

Regarding the recommendations for future research, an aspect worth considering is the expansion of the representative sample to a national level. Continuing on the same lines of a more complete method of performance appraisal, more faculty members should be introduced in the study, such as those in administrative services: individuals with high authority, deans, department heads, program developers, etc.

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